



Göbekli Tepe

The world's oldest known religious site, a complex of temples with intricate relief carvings and inscriptions

The contents of the mound known as Göbekli Tepe ("Potbelly Hill") in southeastern Turkey lay hidden until 1994, when German archaeologist Klaus Schmidt uncovered the first of the T-shaped stone pillars characteristic of the temples there. Further excavation revealed a number of circles of these stones, dating from as early as 10000 BCE, assumed to have a ritual or religious purpose. The pillars range from 10 ft (3 m) to 20 ft (6 m) in height and are set in sockets cut into the polished rock floor, forming a circle around two larger central pillars. It is thought that they were designed to support a roof.



△ BALIKLIĞÖL STATUE

A life-size limestone statue dating from around 9500 BCE was found at an excavation in nearby Balıklıgöl and is now on display in the Museum of Sanliurfa. It is the oldest known Asian statue.

Decorative sculpture

Just as remarkable as the stone structures are the sophisticated, decorative carvings on the individual stones. Cut into the flat surface of many of the pillars, these relief sculptures depict a variety of birds and other animals, including wild game caught by the hunter-gatherer people of the time, as well as some abstract designs and the occasional stylized human figure.



△ COLUMNS AND PILLARS

This image shows one of the circular temples excavated at Göbekli Tepe, with its characteristic central column. In the foreground is a pillar decorated with relief sculptures.



FUSION OF STYLES

The synthesis of local and Classical architecture is most apparent in temples such as that dedicated to the Semitic god Bel. From the outside, it appeared conventionally Classical, if unusually asymmetrical and topped with atypical roof terraces. The details, however, were local to Palmyra: sculptures on the columns and beams depicted local gods and acts of worship. The interior, which included shrines dedicated to indigenous gods, was also decorated in typical local style.

